INFORMATION TO KEEP WITH YOU

My complete treatment handbook

Gefitinib monotherapy

Understand your treatment. Know what to expect. Keep your plan to hand.

Treatment pattern
Ongoing
Follow the prescribed daily plan

Regimen source
NCCP 00220
Version 5

Continuous daily tablets

Inside your handbook

		PAGE
01	Understanding your treatment	2
02	Your schedule, tests and appointments	5
03	Symptoms and supportive care	9
04	Sources and further information	15

My name

Hospital / oncology team

Use the urgent instructions and contact numbers in your treatment guide. Your team must replace example numbers before patient use. Your individual treatment plan takes precedence.

CHAPTER 01

Understanding your treatment

IN THIS CHAPTER

Why this treatment is offered, what its medicines do, and how the agreed plan fits your care.

How this medicine supports your treatment

Gefitinib blocks abnormal EGFR growth signals in selected lung cancers. Treatment aims to control advanced cancer and delay progression.

EGFR TYROSINE KINASE INHIBITOR

Gefitinib

Blocks abnormal EGFR growth signals

Activating EGFR mutation identified → EGFR signalling blocked → Cancer growth slowed

Gefitinib blocks the EGFR tyrosine kinase signal that can drive growth in cancers with activating EGFR mutations. Effects on normal skin and bowel cells also contribute to side effects.

Report diarrhoea, rash, breathing changes and eye symptoms promptly.

Your treatment aim

Which setting?

NCCP 00220a covers adults with locally advanced or metastatic non-small-cell lung cancer (NSCLC) with an activating EGFR mutation. This is continuous treatment for advanced disease, not a fixed adjuvant course.

NCCP 00220 v5 · official regimen · EMA Iressa product information

Duration

The usual dose is 250 mg by mouth once daily, continuously without a planned rest week. Use the dose on your prescription. Treatment continues while it helps and side effects remain acceptable; any change is agreed with your team.

What studies tell us

In a study of previously untreated EGFR-mutated advanced lung cancer, gefitinib delayed progression compared with chemotherapy. The final survival comparison did not show a statistically significant difference. The study population and subsequent treatments matter; ask how the evidence applies to your exact setting.

Your own decision

Ask how the study population matches your situation and discuss alternatives, harms and remaining uncertainty.

IPASS primary trial, Mok et al. 2009 · IPASS final OS and biomarker analysis, Fukuoka et al. 2011

Evidence for this treatment setting

The mutation and prior treatment matter.

Study groups cannot predict your individual outcome or compare treatments from different trials.

When to get help

Emergency: 112 / 999. Severe chest pain, major breathing difficulty, collapse or stroke symptoms need emergency help.

Contact your treating team promptly: Call urgently for new or worsening breathlessness, cough or fever; severe diarrhoea, inability to drink or much less urine; severe or persistent abdominal pain; blistering or peeling skin; or yellow skin/eyes. Eye pain, light sensitivity or blurred vision needs prompt assessment. Severe breathing difficulty, collapse or swelling of the tongue/throat needs emergency help. Use your unit's temperature and 24-hour contact instructions.

YOUR ONCOLOGY TEAM · DAYTIME

Insert numbers here

Acute Oncology Service

YOUR ONCOLOGY TEAM · OUT OF HOURS

Insert numbers here

Ask for medical oncology

EVENINGS / OVERNIGHT

Your agreed out-of-hours pathway

Other hospitals: use the contacts your own team provides.

CHAPTER 02

Your schedule, tests and appointments

IN THIS CHAPTER

Your treatment stages, checks and practical preparations, from before treatment through follow-up.

BASELINE → TREATMENT → FOLLOW-UP

Treatment and monitoring over time

Relative stages, not equal lengths of time or booked appointments. Daily tablets continue between reviews unless the team tells you to hold. Confirm who arranges and reviews every test.

The team arranges and reviews tests. This guide shows expected timing; it does not record completed appointments. NCCP 00220 v5 · official regimen · EMA Iressa product information

THE WHOLE TREATMENT JOURNEY

Gefitinib monotherapy: treatment and checks

Your treatment pattern

Continuous daily tablets

This shows treatment timing, not guaranteed symptom-free days. Your team confirms the active phase and dates.

Activating-EGFR advanced NSCLC

Read from left to right. Columns show stages, not equal lengths of time. This is a general plan: no dates or personal information are needed. Your team confirms which steps apply and arranges appointments.

Treatment, tests and reviews across the course

Care / check	Before the first dose	Early treatment review	Ongoing daily treatment	Benefit / toxicity review	Treatment change or completion
Treatment NCCP 00220 · SMPC	Confirm indication and prescribed dose	Daily gefitinib; no planned rest week	Continue the prescribed dose	Review benefit, harms and dose	Agree next treatment or follow-up
Blood tests NCCP 00220 · SMPC	Blood count, kidney and liver profile	Repeat as clinically indicated	Team sets follow-up tests	Extra tests for dehydration or liver problems	Follow unresolved abnormalities
Symptoms and medicines NCCP 00220 · SMPC	Review lungs, bowel, skin, eyes and medicines	Report bowel, skin or eye symptoms early	Check adherence, supply and interactions	Confirm recovery before restart	Continue advice for unresolved symptoms

Care / check	Before the first dose	Early treatment review	Ongoing daily treatment	Benefit / toxicity review	Treatment change or completion
Cancer assessment NCCP 00220 · SMPC	Confirm EGFR, stage and prior treatment; chest X-ray and computed tomography (CT)	Clinical review	Scans per Consultant plan	Discuss response or progression	Agree follow-up or next treatment

What each check is for

1



Confirm eligibility and the prescription

Before the first dose

The mutation and treatment setting determine applicability.

Ask / act: Document exact indication, dose and initial investigations.

2



Early bowel and skin review

From the first dose and early reviews

Early support can prevent dehydration and uncontrolled skin toxicity.

Ask / act: Record grade, duration, supportive treatment and recovery; apply medicine-specific thresholds.

3

New respiratory symptoms

At any time

Possible interstitial lung disease (ILD) requires urgent investigation.

Ask / act: Arrange urgent assessment and an authorised medicine plan.

4



Benefit and next-plan review

At planned cancer assessments or significant toxicity

Continuous treatment is not an unlimited automatic prescription.

Ask / act: Agree continuation, hold, restart, change or follow-up.

At the next review, ask

- Which treatment phase am I in, and what happens next?
- Which test is expected next, who arranges it, and who explains the result?
- Who should I contact if an expected appointment has not arrived?

This map does not show whether a test has been ordered, booked or completed. Do not wait for a scheduled test if you develop new symptoms.

Checks before and during treatment

Tests and symptoms guide safe treatment decisions.

Before starting

Confirm the activating EGFR result, exact indication, previous treatment and prescription. Check blood count, kidneys and liver. NCCP also specifies baseline chest X-ray and CT scan. Review lungs, bowel, skin, eyes, all medicines and pregnancy precautions.

During treatment

NCCP specifies blood count, kidney and liver tests throughout treatment as clinically indicated. The team sets your appointments and scan plan. Report symptoms promptly; extra checks may be needed for diarrhoea, dehydration or liver problems.

Taking gefitinib

Follow your individual prescription.



Daily tablets

Take once daily with or without food, at about the same time. If missed, take when remembered unless less than 12 hours remain before the next dose; then skip it. Never double a dose. If swallowing is difficult, pharmacy can teach dispersion in non-carbonated water without crushing; drink within 60 minutes and rinse the glass. Ask your team what to do after vomiting; do not take an extra tablet without advice.

Dose changes

For poorly tolerated bowel or skin effects, the source permits a brief interruption of up to 14 days and reinstatement of 250 mg daily. If treatment remains intolerable after interruption, an alternative is considered. Liver impairment requires a separate specialist plan; do not split tablets or calculate half a dose yourself.

CHAPTER 03

Symptoms and supportive care

IN THIS CHAPTER

Recognising changes, knowing when to call, and using your prescribed supportive-care plan.

Daily tablets, checks and decisions

No dates or personal information are needed. Confirm your own appointments with the team.

Treatment or check	Timing in this view
Preparation	**Before the first dose** Confirm the activating EGFR test, indication, prescription and baseline tests.
Daily oral treatment	**Early treatment review → Ongoing daily treatment → Benefit / toxicity review** The usual dose is 250 mg by mouth once daily, continuously without a planned rest week. Use the dose on your prescription. Treatment continues while it helps and side effects remain acceptable; any change is agreed with your team.
Tests and symptoms	**Early treatment review → Ongoing daily treatment → Benefit / toxicity review → Treatment change or completion** NCCP specifies blood count, kidney and liver tests throughout treatment as clinically indicated. The team sets your appointments and scan plan. Report symptoms promptly; extra checks may be needed for diarrhoea, dehydration or liver problems.
Next treatment plan	**Treatment change or completion** Review response, side effects and whether to continue, change or stop treatment.

Take once daily with or without food, at about the same time. If missed, take when remembered unless less than 12 hours remain before the next dose; then skip it. Never double a dose. If swallowing is difficult, pharmacy can teach dispersion in non-carbonated water without crushing; drink within 60 minutes and rinse the glass. Ask your team what to do after vomiting; do not take an extra tablet without advice.

Relative stages, not equal lengths of time or booked appointments. Daily tablets continue between reviews unless the team tells you to hold. Confirm who arranges and reviews every test.

> Columns show sequence, not equal durations. These are reference milestones, not booked appointments. Symptom bands do not predict severity or a safe time to ignore symptoms.

Living with treatment

Report symptoms early and keep contact details available.

Diarrhoea and fluids

Keep the prescribed anti-diarrhoea plan available from the first dose. Report loose stools early and keep drinking if able. Persistent or severe diarrhoea, weakness, inability to drink or much less urine requires urgent advice. The team decides whether to hold treatment and when it is safe to restart.

Skin, nails and mouth

Use the agreed skin, nail and mouth-care plan. Report rash, painful nails or mouth sores early. Emollients and sun protection may help; the team decides whether creams, antibiotics or other treatment are needed. Blistering or peeling skin needs urgent assessment.



Nausea medicines

Gefitinib has minimal-to-low oral emetic risk. Agree any as-needed anti-sickness medicine with the team. Routine infusion premedication is not required.

NCCP 00220 v5 · official regimen · NCCP systemic anticancer therapy (SACT) antiemetic guidance V6 (2025), oral tables · NCCP NCIS antiemetic medicines V8 (2025); parenteral scope



Medicine interactions

Give pharmacy all medicines and supplements. Strong CYP3A4 inducers can reduce exposure; inhibitors and some CYP2D6 interactions can increase risk. Medicines that keep stomach acid low may reduce absorption. Ask for an individual medicine plan; do not borrow timing from another EGFR medicine. Warfarin needs regular blood-clotting checks.

Pregnancy, fertility and breastfeeding

Avoid pregnancy during treatment and discuss effective contraception and future pregnancy plans with the team. NCCP excludes pregnancy and breastfeeding; do not breastfeed during treatment. The cited product information does not specify a universal post-treatment contraception interval, so ask for an individual plan.

When to get urgent help

Do not wait for the next appointment.

Call urgently

Call urgently for new or worsening breathlessness, cough or fever; severe diarrhoea, inability to drink or much less urine; severe or persistent abdominal pain; blistering or peeling skin; or yellow skin/eyes. Eye pain, light sensitivity or blurred vision needs prompt assessment. Severe breathing difficulty, collapse or swelling of the tongue/throat needs emergency help. Use your unit’s temperature and 24-hour contact instructions.

When you call

Give the medicine name, last dose and symptoms. Tell the team if you can drink, pass urine and manage usual activities. Do not delay calling while gathering information.

When treatment changes

The team authorises continuation, interruption, restart or stopping.

Before restarting

Confirm symptom recovery, blood results, the prescribed dose and the next review.

When treatment ends

Agree follow-up, unresolved symptom care and reproductive precautions.

Practical support

Diarrhoea and fluids

Skin, nails and mouth

Nausea medicines

Medicine interactions

Pregnancy, fertility and breastfeeding

Taking tablets / attending treatment

Practical treatment details

Supplies and visits

Arrange the next prescription before tablets run out.

The oral regimen itself does not require an infusion line or pump.

Questions to ask

Explain the plan back: Explain when you take the daily tablet and how food affects it.,What will you do after a missed dose?,Which symptoms require an urgent call?,Who authorises a treatment hold or restart?

Which treatment this guide covers NCCP 00220a covers adults with locally advanced or metastatic non-small-cell lung cancer (NSCLC) with an activating EGFR mutation. This is continuous treatment for advanced disease, not a fixed adjuvant course.

Supportive prescription draft for review. This is a regimen template. It is not an issued patient prescription; individual review and completion are required.

Gefitinib alone · daily oral treatment

Active medicines: gefitinib

Emetogenic risk: Minimal to low (oral)

No routine prophylactic antiemetic order is populated for this phase. Agree an individual symptom-treatment plan where needed.

Additional phase-specific support

- Keep the prescribed anti-diarrhoea plan available from the first dose. Report loose stools early and keep drinking if able. Persistent or severe diarrhoea, weakness, inability to drink or much less urine requires urgent advice. The team decides whether to hold treatment and when it is safe to restart.
- Use the agreed skin, nail and mouth-care plan. Report rash, painful nails or mouth sores early. Emollients and sun protection may help; the team decides whether creams, antibiotics or other treatment are needed. Blistering or peeling skin needs urgent assessment.
- Gefitinib has minimal-to-low oral emetic risk. Agree any as-needed anti-sickness medicine with the team. Routine infusion premedication is not required.
- Give pharmacy all medicines and supplements. Strong CYP3A4 inducers can reduce exposure; inhibitors and some CYP2D6 interactions can increase risk. Medicines that keep stomach acid low may reduce absorption. Ask for an individual medicine plan; do not borrow timing from another EGFR medicine. Warfarin needs regular blood-clotting checks.
- Avoid pregnancy during treatment and discuss effective contraception and future pregnancy plans with the team. NCCP excludes pregnancy and breastfeeding; do not breastfeed during treatment. The cited product information does not specify a universal post-treatment contraception interval, so ask for an individual plan.

Before signing: verify allergies, current medicines, interactions, renal / hepatic function, QT risk, sedation, prior response, total steroid exposure and the rescue-medicine duration. Do not duplicate medicines from another phase.

Individual changes / rescue duration: _____
Prescriber / date: _____ Pharmacy review: _____

Which treatment this guide covers National Cancer Control Programme (NCCP) 00220a covers adults with locally advanced or metastatic non-small-cell lung cancer (NSCLC) with an activating EGFR mutation. This is continuous treatment for advanced disease, not a fixed adjuvant course.

NCCP 00220 · VERSION 5

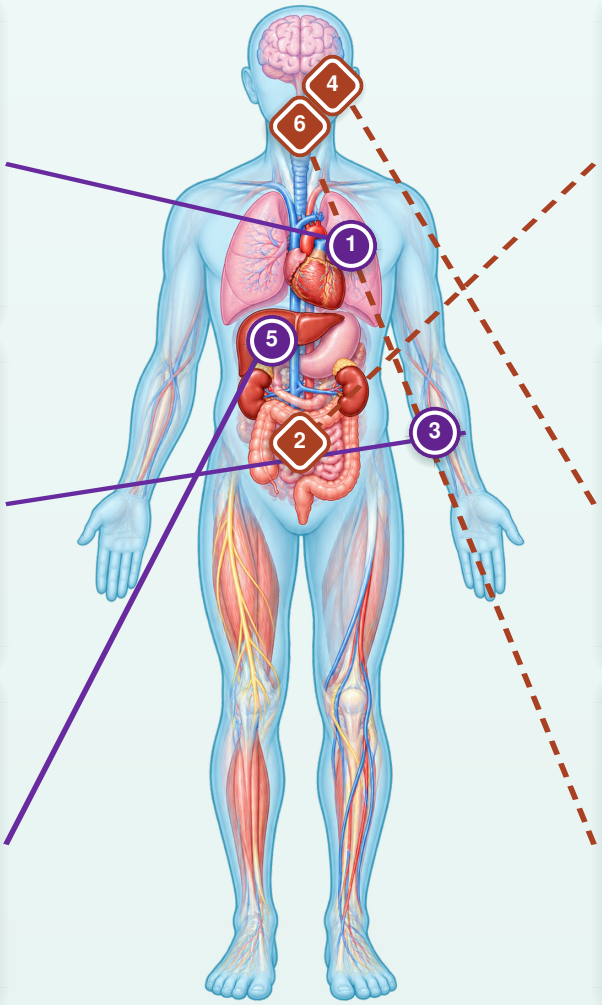
Gefitinib monotherapy

The usual dose is 250 mg by mouth once daily, continuously without a planned rest week. Use the dose on your prescription. Treatment continues while it helps and side effects remain acceptable; any change is agreed with your team.

Daily EGFR-targeted tablets · selected medicine-specific effects. Full details and sources are in the complete reference.

A picture of side effects

Numbered symptom boxes connect to the anatomical illustration. The medicine responsible may be uncertain; report the symptom.



1 Lungs

gefitinib

New cough or breathlessness needs urgent assessment.

2 Bowel

gefitinib

Diarrhoea can cause dehydration; follow the symptom plan.

3 Skin and nails

gefitinib

Report rash, painful nails or peeling skin.

4 Eyes

gefitinib

Eye pain or blurred vision needs prompt review.

5 Liver

gefitinib

Blood tests check for liver injury.

6 Mouth

gefitinib

Report soreness or difficulty eating.

Selected effects, not every possible effect or a prediction. Blood-count, skin and line markers are schematic. Number and text carry meaning; colour is decorative.

Call urgently for new or worsening breathlessness, cough or fever; severe diarrhoea, inability to drink or much less urine; severe or persistent abdominal pain; blistering or peeling skin; or yellow skin/eyes. Eye pain, light sensitivity or blurred vision needs prompt assessment. Severe breathing difficulty, collapse or swelling of the tongue/throat needs emergency help. Use your unit's temperature and 24-hour contact instructions. Severe chest pain, major breathing difficulty, collapse or stroke symptoms: 112 / 999.

CHAPTER 04

Sources and further information

IN THIS CHAPTER

The references behind this information and addresses you can use to find further help.

Use this information alongside the plan agreed with your treatment team. Your team confirms your medicines, doses and appointments.

1. **NCCP 00220 v5 · official regimen**
   https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/6937/220_V5_Gefitinib_Monotherapy.pdf
2. **EMA Iressa product information**
   https://www.ema.europa.eu/en/documents/product-information/iressa-epar-product-information_en.pdf
3. **NCCP V6 oral minimal-low: individual as-required antiemetics; NCIS V8 is parenteral and does not prescribe an oral course**
   https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/7152/Classification_Document_for_Systemic_Anti-_Cancer_Therapy_systemic anticancer therapy (SACT)_Induced_Nausea__pWgDCrm.pdf
4. **NCCP NCIS antiemetic medicines V8 (2025); parenteral scope**
   https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/7180/Supportive_Care_Antiemetics_for_inclusion_NCIS_Medical_Oncology.pdf
5. **IPASS primary trial, Mok et al. 2009**
   https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/19692680/
6. **IPASS final OS and biomarker analysis, Fukuoka et al. 2011**
   https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/21670455/